Lighten Your Load

AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDES · OCTOBER 2026

What's on the food we eat?

Three free guides to pesticide residues in Australian fruit and vegetables, built from the best available Australian data and clearly labelled where it runs out.

- **The Dirty Dozen AU** — Highest evidence of residues — prioritise organic — p. 2
- **Tread Carefully** — Not Dirty Dozen, but worth knowing — p. 4
- **Fill Your Basket** — Lowest evidence of residues — conventional is generally a reasonable choice — p. 6

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General information only, not medical or dietary advice. Talk to a qualified health professional about your own diet. Rankings are informed estimates based on available evidence; sources are listed in each guide and in full on the website.

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LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

The Dirty Dozen AU

The 12 Australian produce items with the highest evidence of pesticide contamination. Ranked approximately by strength of Australian-specific evidence - prioritise organic versions, especially for children and during pregnancy.

PRIORITISE ORGANIC WHEN…

- → Your children eat it regularly — children absorb more and eliminate pesticides less efficiently than adults
- → It's imported AND on this list — source countries may permit chemicals banned in Australia
- → You are pregnant — especially strawberries, leafy greens, and stone fruit
- → You eat it daily — start with your most frequent items first
- → Budget is limited — focus on items #1–6 where the AU evidence is strongest

⚠ **Data note:** Australia has no equivalent to the US Environmental Working Group (EWG) Dirty Dozen program. This guide synthesises all available AU data plus international findings where AU data is absent. Rankings are informed estimates, not definitive science. Absence of AU data does not mean absence of risk — it often means absence of independent investigation.

1 

Strawberries

Buy Organic

10% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011, second only to apples among fresh produce (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). In CHOICE's 2008 test of strawberries from 31 growers, one sample exceeded the Australian legal limit and two more exceeded stricter EU limits for captan. Unpublished government data, obtained under FOI by Guardian Australia, showed dimethoate at up to 90× the Australian MRL. Dimethoate: banned in the EU since 2019; possible human carcinogen (US EPA).

2 

Apples

Buy Organic

Highest pesticide detection count in AU monitoring data 2000–2011 (Friends of the Earth Melbourne). The Food Standards Code sets apple residue limits for 136 chemicals. Post-harvest diphenylamine widely used (banned EU).

3 

Spinach & leafy greens

Buy Organic

Large surface area absorbs systemic pesticides that cannot be washed off. Consistent highest-risk class globally and in AU monitoring data.

4 

Grapes

Buy Organic

6.4% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011. Multiple fungicides applied repeatedly. Thin skin — cannot be peeled.

5 

Stone fruit

Buy Organic

peaches, nectarines, apricots, plums, cherries (most stone fruit: limited AU data)

Unpublished government testing (2013), revealed under FOI by Guardian Australia, found fenthion at unacceptable levels in nine peach samples and one apricot. Fenthion has since been withdrawn in Australia. PFAS fludioxonil found on 90% of peach & plum samples (EWG 2026).

6 

Blueberries

Buy Organic

Chlorpyrifos & thiometon detected in AU blueberries (FSANZ 2011). Southern Cross University (2025): 3 samples had dimethoate at levels that could exceed the safe daily intake if eaten daily. APVMA suspended dimethoate use on blueberries, raspberries and blackberries (November 2025).

7 

Pears

Buy Organic

9.5% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011 — third among fresh produce, after apples and strawberries (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). High fungicide use. Diphenylamine post-harvest (banned EU).

8 

Raspberries & blackberries

Buy Organic

91% of blackberry samples had detectable pesticides, avg 4+ per sample (EWG 2026). PFAS bifenthrin detected. Same APVMA dimethoate suspension covers raspberries & blackberries (2025).

9 

Lettuce

Buy Organic

4.1% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011 (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). No outer skin — entire surface is eaten.

10 

Capsicum / bell peppers

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin. Ranks just below the Dirty Dozen globally on overall pesticide toxicity.

11 

Celery

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS data. No outer peel — every stalk surface is exposed. Very high surface area-to-volume ratio. 64 different pesticides detected internationally.

12 

Kale & Asian greens

Buy Organic

High pest pressure, systemic pesticide use documented. Limited AU-specific testing but biology identical to highest-risk leafy class. Tops EWG 2026 on toxicity weighting.

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth Melbourne (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Southern Cross University (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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Tread Carefully

Commonly eaten items that don't belong on the Dirty Dozen - but carry specific concerns worth knowing about. Simple actions reduce risk significantly for most of these.

TREAD CAREFULLY ACTIONS

- → Peel potatoes & cucumbers thoroughly - removes most surface residues effectively
- → Buy AU-grown garlic & citrus - significantly lower chemical load than imported equivalents
- → Buy local tomatoes - avoids the QLD mandatory interstate transit insecticide treatment
- → Organic ginger worthwhile for daily users - soil absorption makes washing largely ineffective
- → Choose frozen green beans over fresh - blanching before freezing degrades residues meaningfully

⚠ **Data note:** "Tread Carefully" does not mean avoid - it means be informed. For most items here, simple actions (peeling, buying local, washing well) meaningfully reduce risk. Organic is advisable where the item is eaten daily or frequently by children.

LISTED IN ALPHABETICAL ORDER.



Broccoli & broccolini

Wash well

Lower risk than leafy greens but not negligible. Dense head provides some protection. Wash in running water getting into the florets. Organic worthwhile if eaten daily.



Cucumbers

Peel

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin with moderate pesticide use. Sits in the middle of global rankings - not Dirty Dozen but not clean. Peeling removes most surface residues.



Garlic

Buy AU-grown

Most supermarket garlic is imported from China. In 2010–11, China was second only to India for imported food breaching Australian chemical residue limits (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). Papery skin offers some protection - buy Australian-grown where labelled.



Ginger

Organic

Underground tuber absorbs residual soil pesticides during growth. Almost entirely imported into Australia. Clothianidin detected at high rates in Chinese ginger. Washing is largely ineffective.



Green beans

Wash well

Thin edible pod, high pest pressure. Acephate residues found internationally despite a decade-old ban. AU-specific data is limited but biology is comparable. Frozen green beans are lower risk.



Oranges & citrus

Buy AU-grown

Post-harvest imazalil fungicide (linked to hormone disruption) penetrates the peel into the flesh. Found on ~90% of peeled samples. Imported citrus carries 4× higher levels than AU-grown.



Potatoes

Peel well

90% of samples contain chlorpropham — a post-harvest sprout inhibitor banned in the EU since 2019, still approved in Australia. Concentrated in the skin — peel thoroughly.



Rockmelon

Scrub before cutting

Recent testing found three pesticides on rockmelon, including a systemic neonicotinoid not approved in the EU, and a post-harvest fungicide. The netted rind traps surface residues. Scrub it before cutting so the knife doesn't drag them into the flesh.



Snow peas & sugar snap peas

Wash well

Whole edible pod eaten fresh - no pesticide barrier. Predominantly AU-grown. Only industry-funded residue data available; independent testing is limited.



Tomatoes

Buy local

QLD produce is legally required to be treated with a systemic insecticide dip before interstate transit. Buy locally grown where possible and check origin labelling.



Zucchini

Wash well

Thin edible skin, moderate pesticide use. Similar biology and risk profile to cucumbers. Generally AU-grown with limited independent residue data available.

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth Melbourne (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Hort Innovation (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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Fill Your Basket

Cleaner by far: the Australian produce with the lowest evidence of pesticide risk. Conventional versions are generally a reasonable choice, saving your organic budget for the Dirty Dozen.

GENERAL PRACTICES

- → Check country of origin - AU-grown Dirty Dozen items are preferable to imported equivalents
- → Soak in baking soda solution (1 tsp per 2 cups water, 15 minutes) then rinse - reduces surface residues more effectively than water alone
- → Farmers markets - ask about spray practices; many small AU farms use organic methods without formal certification
- → Grow your own - focus effort on Dirty Dozen crops: strawberries, leafy greens, kale, and berries

More fresh produce is always better than less! These carry lower residues than most, so fill your basket, and spend your organic dollars where they count most.

LISTED IN ALPHABETICAL ORDER.



Asparagus

Cleanest

Consistently on the EWG Clean Fifteen — fewer than 11% of samples globally show any detectable residues. Short growing season limits spray applications, and thick stalks offer natural protection. Buy AU-grown in season (Sept–Feb) where available.



Avocados

Cleanest

Thick inedible skin. Less than 2% of samples globally show any residues. Consistently the cleanest item on any produce list.



Bananas

Peeled before eating — flesh well protected. 2026 EWG Clean Fifteen. Note: conventional banana skins carry post-harvest fungicide residues — avoid feeding peels to wildlife.



Beetroot

Underground crop, thick skin almost always peeled. Low pest pressure. Low residues internationally.



Cabbage

Outer leaves discarded. Produces glucosinolates that naturally deter insects, reducing how much spraying is needed.



Carrots

Underground crop, skin discarded. On 2026 EWG Clean Fifteen. Low residue data in AU and globally.

Cauliflower

Dense tightly packed head, outer leaves discarded. Low residues in all available data. Predominantly AU-grown.

Eggplant

Thick skin, lower pest pressure than thin-skinned crops. Low detection rates. Predominantly AU-grown.

Frozen garden peas (shelled)

Protective pod discarded before freezing. Very low residues. Distinct from snow peas — the whole pod is not eaten.

Kiwifruit

Skin not consumed. 82% of samples globally had zero detectable residues in the flesh.

Leeks

Allium family — outer layers discarded. Low pest pressure. Predominantly AU-grown. Consistent with onion and shallot residue profile.

Mangoes

Thick inedible skin, low residues. Buy local QLD/NT where possible — interstate transit treatment applies to some mangoes.

Mushrooms

Grown in controlled indoor environments in AU. Low pesticide use. Generally low residues in available data.

Onions

Papery outer skin. Low pest pressure. Very low residues in AU data. Allium family consistently clean.

Papaya / Pawpaw

Thick skin, flesh well-protected. Low detection rates. Both AU-grown and imported perform well globally.

Pineapples

Very thick inedible skin — near-zero residue detections globally. Mainly imported but flesh is well protected.

Pumpkin

Thick inedible skin. Low pest pressure. Flesh consistently clean globally. Predominantly AU-grown.



Shallots & spring onions

Allium family — papery layers, low pest pressure. Short-cycle crop, predominantly AU-grown. Low residues.



Sweet corn

Husk protection. Very low residues. AU sweet corn is non-GMO unlike many US equivalents.



Sweet potato

Underground crop, skin usually peeled. Low residue rates. A common AU kitchen staple with a reassuring profile.



Watermelon

Very thick rind. Flesh well insulated from chemicals. Low residues across all global studies consistently.

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth Melbourne (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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